

resulted in him receiving an earful from Colonel Gold, the Brigade Commander, whom I'm sure that you have met at an FRG meeting or two. For now, we have resorted to singing our own version of the African-American spiritual "We Shall Overcome." It is sung to the same tune and cadence, just the words have been altered slightly:

"We Shall Leave Iraq,"

"We Shall Leave Iraq."

"Someday, Someday."

At least it passes time. Kimball, the Chaplain, and I have worked to make our room a little more habitable. There are chairs and makeshift tables, and we sit around and listen to music in the small amount of free time we have available.

In the meantime, the action is minimal—or at least it seems that way. We have approximately one minor incident per day, but nothing catastrophic since the death of Master Sergeant Payne. Today, for example, some unknown Iraqi placed an explosive device on one of our tanks that was guarding a gas station. We don't know if it was a homemade device of a grenade, either way the assailant got away and no one was injured. Nowadays, any attacks against US Forces seem to be quick, unplanned attacks and rarely result in any injuries. On the other hand, though, it is getting more difficult to catch the bad guys. It used to be that if someone attacked us, we caught them right away. Now, they seem to disappear into the large crowds that are everywhere. The city is returning to normal and this gives the bad guys more places to hide.

Yesterday, I sat in on a preliminary meeting with LTC Ingram and some Iraqis that had been identified as possible local community leaders. The meeting lasted forever and I was primarily responsible for flipping Powerpoint slides, but it was interesting nonetheless. The Iraqis were mainly from the Amerreea neighborhood, in the western part of our sector. They ranged in age, social status and education. One was a former Iraqi soldier, a young Arab man with an intense stare. Another was a dentist with a degree from Iowa State University. And another was a local sheik who spoke seven languages and had many degrees from both the United States and England. The meeting was interesting because it represented the first steps toward a new government in Iraq.

Our staff had prepared an agenda for the "Citizen's Council Meeting" that covered all the different aspects of our operation in the city. These guys argued relentlessly about every topic on the agenda, with everyone speaking at once. They wore out our interpreter and we had to change them out halfway through the meeting. They wanted to know why they wouldn't be allowed to shoot their AK-47s inside the city limits and how to get the newly implemented weapons permits. They were worried about security, financial issues, and health care. You name it, they argued about it. It was quite the spectacle of Arabic chatter and confrontation. In the end, nothing was resolved in the initial meeting, but everyone agreed to come back for the second council. We will see how it develops.